

SCANDAL

They get priority in jobs, benefits of welfare schemes and all the related perks of belonging to the Scheduled Tribes. The only problem is that they are not tribals but ovc Kshatriyas masquerading as ones and have for years been denying the rightful beneficiaries of their due.



Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL

Based on his complaint, the district vigilance officer held an inquiry and found that Raval was a fake tribal. The officer has now recommended that a police case be filed against Raval for manipulation of documents to get a tribal status. Even before the elections, Taviad had lodged a complaint with the election officer regarding the fake tribal status of Raval but nothing had come of that.

The large-scale fraud came to light in 1995 when officials in the Keshubhai Patel government found that Kshatriyas, who had distinct surnames and customs, were moving around with ST certificates in Panchmahal and Vadodra and stopped issuing them the certificates. After a Supreme Court order in 2000, a state-level vigilance committee was ap-

◀ VILLAGE GOLANPUR, KADANA TALUKA

A majority of the people in Golanpur are Kshatriyas but have taken ST certificates. With the law catching up with them they have turned belligerent and threaten to launch an agitation against the government's "injustice".

▼ LAXMAN S. KHANT and LATABEN KHANT, VILLAGE UBER, SANTRAMPUR

Laxman, 63, is an OBC while his daughter Lata, 30, is an ST and secured a job as a schoolteacher on that basis. Even Lata's husband Jawanbhai Pateliya, 32, got a schoolteacher's job on the basis of his fake tribal status.

Constitution. The genuine tribals are victims of vote-bank politics." Adds Pratap Damor, another genuine tribal and sarpanch of Singar village near Santrampur: "Steps are needed on a war footing to curb the menace."

A poor tribal leader Natwarbhai Vaghjibhai Taviad, 45, who lost the panchayat elections to Naranbhai Lallu Raval of Gothim village, Santrampur, who moves around in a Bolero Jeep, says: "We genuine tribals are victims of manipulation which the government should stop immediately."

